



THE INSTITUTE OF
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Chief Examiner's Report

2024 Stage 2 MW Exam

Each year our examiners and in particular the paper and panel chairs spend a great deal of time reflecting on the papers they have marked and analysing the year's results. The examiners' reports are carefully considered to provide helpful information for those sitting the exam in coming years. We are disappointed to see a number of important points highlighted in previous examiners' reports that continue to be problematic for candidates in the exam, so my first piece of advice would be to read and understand these reports. If anything is unclear to you, ask questions.

There is a concern among the examiners that an over-reliance on the excellent study programme is eroding students' ability to think for themselves. Ours is a guided self-study programme and one in which students should question everything at every stage. Those who simply assimilate information that is provided for them and repeat this in the exam room will not pass the exam.

There is evidence of a general lack of critical thinking seen throughout the exam. In the practical exam, correct identification is not the only thing, it is necessary to support answers with evidence from the glass and draw conclusions as directed by the question being asked. In the theory exam, all too often the examples used are those presented at seminars, much technical detail is rote-learned and repeated in the exam without any proper consideration of the actual question being asked, which may require a more nuanced interpretation of the information. In the research paper, data may not be interrogated in a sufficiently rigorous manner. I would therefore urge all candidates to be very honest with themselves about whether their critical thinking skills are going to let them down at any stage of the MW exam.

In this year's exam 51 candidates failed all three of the practical papers, and 50 candidates failed all five of the theory papers. These candidates should consider very carefully whether they are ready to sit the closed book exam. Don't sit the exam as soon as you enter stage 2 unless or until you know you can confidently expect to pass at least one paper in either the theory or practical exam. You have the option to defer the exam once - use it wisely.

On a more positive note, there is a continuing trend of a good number of clear passes on one or both parts of the closed book exam, particularly amongst those sitting the exam at their first and second attempts. This would suggest that we are seeing some candidates much better prepared to sit the exam, often with high marks across most papers.

Those candidates proceeding to Stage 3, so very well supported by the RP team, should not abscond responsibility for getting themselves over the line. It is very regrettable to see RP candidates depriving themselves of the time necessary to complete the RP successfully and in doing so demonstrate the critical skills necessary for success in the MW programme.

Neil Tully MW, Chief Examiner